it, Nordstrom's theory ... is much more plausible. But it, too, is built on [flat, Minkowskian spacetime], the belief in which amounts, I feel, to something like a superstition."

In April 1914 Einstein left the ETH for a professorship in Berlin which carried no teaching duties. At last he could work on research as much as he wished, and even do so in the stimulating vicinity of Berlin's great physicists, Max Planck and Walther Nernst. In Berlin, despite the June 1914 outbreak of the First World War, Einstein continued his quest for an acceptable description of how matter curves space-time, a description that did not rely on any special class of reference frames—an improved law of warpage.

A three-hour train ride from Berlin, in the university village of Gottingen where Minkowski had worked, there lived one of the greatest mathematicians of all time: David Hilbert. During 1914 and 1915 Hilbert pursued a passionate interest in physics. Einstein's published ideas fascinated him, so in late June of 1915 he invited Einstein down for a visit. Einstein stayed for about a week and gave six two-hour lectures to Hilbert and his colleagues. Several days after the visit Einstein wrote to a friend, "I had the great joy of seeing in Göttingen that everything [about my work] is understood to the last detail. With Hilbert I am just enraptured."

Several months after returning to Berlin, Einstein became more deeply distressed than ever with the Einstein-Grossmann law of warpage. Not only did it violate his vision that the laws of gravity should be the same in all reference frames, but also, he discovered after arduous calculation, it gave a wrong value for the anomalous perihelion shift of Mercury's orbit. He had hoped his theory would explain the perihelion shift, thereby triumphantly resolving the shift's discrepancy with Newton's laws. Such an achievement would give at least some experimental confirmation that his laws of gravity were right and Newton's wrong. However, his calculation, based on the Einstein—Grossmann law of warpage, gave a perihelion shift half as large as was observed.

Pouring over his old calculations with Grossmann, Einstein discovered a few crucial mistakes. Feverishly he worked through the month of October, and on 4 November he presented, at the weekly plenary session of the Prussian Academy of Sciences in Berlin, an account of his mistakes and a